

In the closet

Throughout history, clothes have inspired some major changes. Cloth-making inventions, such as the loom, were the main forces behind the Industrial Revolution of the 18th and 19th centuries. Clothes vary across the world, but sometimes an item of clothing is so useful it becomes popular everywhere.

KEEPING OUT THE RAIN

In 1824, the Scottish chemist Charles Macintosh invented a waterproof coat made from rubber-filled fabric. Named after their inventor, early “Mackintoshes” tended to melt in hot weather. The British engineer Thomas Hancock solved this by devising a process using heat and sulfur, called vulcanization, to make the rubber stronger.



Mackintosh coat, 1922



THE MODERN BRA

An American woman called Mary Jacob is said to have invented the first modern-style, lightweight brassiere, which was patented in 1914. According to the story, finding that her bulky corset poked out of a new dress, she designed a replacement piece of underwear using a couple of handkerchiefs and a few ribbons.



A needle moves up and down, linking threads above and below the cloth.

FAST STITCHING

In the mid-19th century, several American inventors came up with designs for a sewing machine, but from 1851 onward it was Isaac Singer's machine that had the greatest success. However, his device was so similar to one made by another inventor, Elias Howe, that Howe sued Singer—and won. The two men would later go into business together.



Lightweight material lets air pass to the feet.

Rubber soles

SNEAKY SHOES

The American inventor Wait Webster patented an idea for making flexible shoes by attaching a rubber sole to a leather upper in 1832. But true sports shoes, called sneakers or trainers, did not appear until the invention of molded rubber soles that gave a good grip. The first-ever sneakers, introduced in 1916, were so named because their rubber soles allowed the wearer to sneak up on someone.